

The lion (*Panthera leo*) is a large [cat](#) of the genus *Panthera*, native to [Sub-Saharan Africa](#) and [India](#). It has a muscular, broad-chested [body](#); a short, rounded head; round ears; and a dark, hairy tuft at the tip of its tail. It is [sexually dimorphic](#); adult male lions are larger than females and have a prominent mane. It is a [social species](#), forming groups called prides. A lion's pride consists of a few adult males, related females, and cubs. Groups of female lions usually hunt together, preying mostly on medium-sized and large [ungulates](#). The lion is an [apex](#) and [keystone predator](#).

The lion inhabits [grasslands](#), [savannahs](#), and [shrublands](#). It is usually more [diurnal](#) than other wild cats, but when persecuted, it adapts to being active [at night](#) and [at twilight](#). During the [Neolithic](#) period, the lion ranged throughout Africa and Eurasia, from Southeast Europe to India, but it has been reduced to fragmented populations in sub-Saharan Africa and one population in [western India](#). It has been listed as [Vulnerable](#) on the [IUCN Red List](#) since 1996 because populations in African countries have declined by about 43% since the early 1990s. Lion populations are untenable outside designated protected areas. Although the cause of the decline is not fully understood, [habitat loss](#) and conflicts with humans are the greatest causes for concern.

One of the most widely recognised animal symbols in human culture, the lion has been extensively depicted in sculptures and paintings, on national flags, and in literature and films. Lions have been kept in [menageries](#) since the time of the [Roman Empire](#) and have been a key species sought for exhibition in [zoological gardens](#) across the world since the late 18th century. [Cultural depictions of lions](#) have occurred worldwide, particularly as a symbol of power and royalty.

Etymology

The English word *lion* is derived via [Anglo-Norman](#) *liun* from [Latin](#) *leōnem* (nominative: *leō*), which in turn was a borrowing from [Ancient Greek](#) λέων *léōn*. The [Hebrew](#) word לָאוֹן *la'ōn* may also be related.^[4] The generic name *Panthera* is traceable to the [classical Latin](#) word 'panthēra' and the [ancient Greek](#) word πάνθηρ 'panther'